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## **A Conversation on the Future of Theory**

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## **"Create, she said.": Deleuze and Feminism (On Dorothea Olkowski's *Gilles Deleuze and the Ruin of Representation*)**

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In Dorothea Olkowski's *Gilles Deleuze and the Ruin of Representation*,<sup>1</sup> the crucial importance of the work of art enters discussion many times, mostly around the work of contemporary artist and feminist Mary Kelly. In Kelly's *Post-partum Document*, the very question of "creation" is posed in the most striking and, perhaps, most obvious of terms: the creation of life itself.<sup>2</sup> The *Post-partum Document* concerns the artist's detailed rendering of the birth of her son and his early years of development. Here, we can already glimpse the relation of this act of creation, purely descriptive, with the creation of the child in the biological and physiological, as well as in the linguistic or sociological senses of the word. It is the limit where both senses of "creation" must meet and fold upon each other that Kelly's work interrogates and, in turn, that Olkowski demonstrates the importance of Kelly's art for the task of feminist philosophy that Olkowski aptly calls in her title "the ruin of representation."

The death of speech is therefore the horizon and origin of language. But an origin and a horizon which do not hold themselves at its external borders. As always, death, which is neither a present to come or a present past, shapes the interior of speech, as its trace, or reserve, its interior and exterior difference: as its supplement.<sup>3</sup>

To remain with Derrida's argument for a moment ' not for long though; like Irigaray before her, Olkowski will not be content with this obsession "with death and mastery" and will seek to orient her thinking in a new direction ' this can be described as the that is limit internal to representation itself. It arises from the metaphorical slippage upon which the generalizing function of representation is founded, whereby death installs itself already or always already at the place of an origin that is twice inaccessible. From this we know that at the basis of the subject is "nothing," or rather, the "trace" of a founding act which has never been present *and nonetheless* institutes subjectivity in language. Consequently, since the supplement is neither a presence nor an absence, Derrida remarks in a line that precedes the above passage, "no ontology can think its operation."<sup>4</sup>

[T]his is where the work of Mary Kelly comes into play, for it is both a critique of objectified representation and a creation of new points of view. Kelly's forms of expression are a new orientation in life for herself as a woman, an orientation she creates in works of art through the organization of images, objects, and words. [...] To see in Kelly's art not just a destructive force but also a creative force of difference, it might help to make sense of the difference between the logic of difference and the logic of representation.

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<sup>1</sup>Dorothea Olkowski, *Gilles Deleuze and the Ruin of Representation* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999).

<sup>2</sup>Mary Kelly, *Post-Partum Document* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999).

<sup>3</sup>Derrida, 315.

<sup>4</sup>Derrida, 314.

Concerning this process, Olkowski writes the following:

> Kelly is obviously unwilling to accept the psychoanalytic interpretation and representation

In the above passage, what I understand Olkowski to be suggesting is that the event of this "[Other]). This opens the possibility of singular deviations or differences that cannot be account

> Perhaps this is why it seemed crucial, not in a sense of moral imperative, but as a historic

I would like to emphasize two words from this passage which I think are crucial to the context Partum Document\_, "one of the most central and perhaps most controversial questions this parti representational impulse that is also at the origin of the work of art, which produces its so-called de-realizing effects. But this is not necessarily so, since we also know of the de-realizing or non-representational power of male perversion (here I am thinking here of Freud's

> these analyses have operated with categorical generalizations: concepts neither abstract en established, even naturalized, standards . . . , it hardly seems fruitful to continue down the

In fact, Olkowski asks concerning the impulse to define women's point-of-view in exclusive and of-view that liberal society excludes women?"[^14] Therefore, it is on the basis of this proble over" and problem-solving approach, by the creation of a new conceptual language and schema for

> Instead \[of the questions of the feminine as essentially transgressive, or the problematic

At the same time, as Kelly immediately goes on to say, "certain feminists began to worry about woman," which as we know from Deleuze and Guattari's description, also entails other \_becomings: molecular," "invisible" or "imperceptible"). Some have speculated that this could only lead to woman" that feminists would unwittingly do themselves in and cause the social identity women to

> I would say that Merleau-Ponty's formulation of the question is caught up in a spatialization seen, the seer is the sight from the point of view of other seers, other worlds: sexual difference Ponty suggests, for that comes to close to eliminating difference, unless narcissism can be re configured as something creative. \[...\] Sexual difference remains in reserve, but, at least v

> This double-capture, which is constitutive of knowledge-Being, could not be created between Being, as opposed to knowledge-Being. It is the informal forces or power relations that set up

Situating the above passage in the context of Olkowski's argument, if phenomenology does not open this ancient \_polemos\_ which had been resolved or pacified too precipitously? And already of view" been most responsible for bringing this second figure of Being, this power-Being, most clearly into view? "From epistemology to strategy" would this not already be the s

> Since woman and man cannot stand in for one another, since they are incommensurable (each b

The question , therefore, that Olkowski poses in conclusion is whether and in what way the pr

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## Notes

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